



**The great talisman:** Mikel Arteta arrived in 2019, won the FA Cup in his first season, then rebuilt Arsenal from successive eighth-place finishes into Premier League champion nearly seven years later. AP

There were still moments when the old fear returned. Arsenal lost twice to City in April during a damaging run across competitions, and the season briefly seemed ready to follow a familiar path. But the collapse never came. The response was not spectacular, but mature. Clean sheets returned, margins were protected. The final weeks became less about performance and more about temperament. In title races, that is often the difference.

When City drew at Bournemouth, Arsenal's players watched together and celebrated far away from the pitch. Supporters gathered around the Emirates as flares lit the streets of north London. It was not the cinematic ending of a home win and a final whistle. It was something more Arsenal-like for this era: a title delivered through accumulated work, tension and a result managed from afar.

**Sealed in style:** Arsenal's Kai Havertz celebrates after scoring against Burnley. Manchester City's draw with Bournemouth was enough for the Gunners to secure the Premier League title. AP



The triumph did not erase the years in between, but it softened them. The frustration, the mockery, the 'bottlers' tag and the seasons that ended with Arsenal looking over its shoulder all became part of the climb rather than proof of failure.

Arteta's greatest achievement is not only Arsenal winning the title again. It is that he has changed what Arsenal was allowed to be. The club can still value craft, but it no longer has to be defined by it. It can win with Saka's touch, Rice's drive, Raya's saves, Saliba's composure, Gabriel's headers and a crowd of players attacking a corner. It can be elegant when possible and ruthless when necessary.

The Premier League trophy returns to Arsenal after 22 years, but this is not a return to the Invincibles. It is the end of a different journey. The years of almos, the jokes, the collapses, the 'not yet' seasons, the springtime anxieties and the wait for another team to slip: Arsenal has lived through all of it.

Now, finally, it has outlasted it.